2
Bonds of Blood with the ‘Mahrattas’

During the First World War, in the campaign in Mesopotamia, my grandfather’s battalion, the 1/67 Punjabis, had fought alongside five ‘Mahratta’ battalions.[1] These included the 5th Royal ‘Mahrattas’ as part of 6th Poona Division led by Major General Charles Townshend. Life has a way of coming full circle. This was the same battalion that I had the great privilege to command from 1985 to 1987 in Hyderabad, seventy years later.

In the siege of Kut-el-Amara (in present-day Iraq), the 6th Division of the British Indian Army was surrounded and cut off by the Turkish forces as shown in Sketch 2.1. During this battle, which lasted from November 1915 to April 1916, the defenders had to go on half-rations, then on a quarter, and finally, they had to eat their own mules or starve to death. The ‘Mahratta’ soldiers refused to eat horse flesh. It was then that Chhatrapati Shahu Maharaj, their king and descendant of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj, appealed to the soldiers in a cable that ‘survival is more important and essential than superstitions and taboos’. Finally, famished, exhausted and depleted, the division had to capitulate. All the gallant officers and men ended up as prisoners of war (POWs) of the Turks. These POWs were made to march across the Iraqi desert to Syria. Further, they had to undergo hard labour and were employed by the Turkish army to construct the railway to connect this region with Syria and Turkey. Some were even subjected to torture while in captivity. Most of them perished due to sickness, malnutrition or torture.